

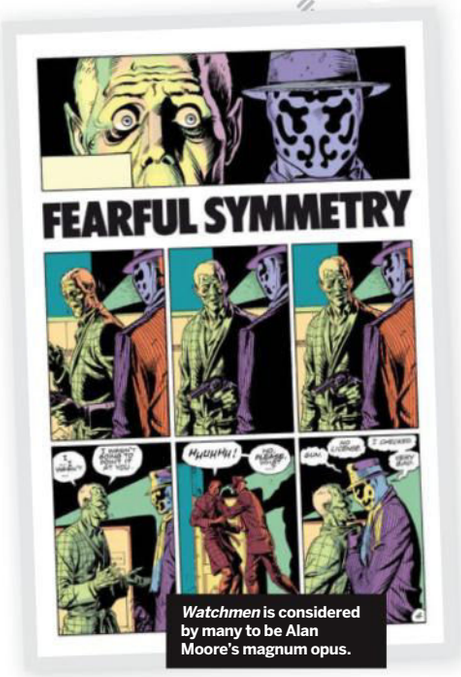


Alan Moore

Comics wizard Alan Moore talks about Watchmen's impact and the moment he knew that he had something revolutionary on his hands

In the mid-Eighties, comics changed. Dramatically. Part of this was down to a classic superhero who surprised everyone by suddenly acting darker and more adult than he'd ever been before. Yet, at the same time, a vigorously bearded gentleman named Alan Moore, who had made quite a reputation for himself in the United States comics scene, was showing what comics could *really* do.

Alan Moore's *Watchmen* remains to this day one of the greatest comics to ever see print. A 12-part 400-page graphic novel, *Watchmen* was originally going to utilise a number of low-tier superhero characters owned by Charlton Comics, which had then recently been bought by DC Comics. What ultimately emerged was something genuinely revolutionary. A veritable masterpiece of comic book storytelling bearing a flawless structure, *Watchmen* was astounding and is still widely hailed by many as the best superhero story ever made.



***Watchmen* is considered by many to be Alan Moore's magnum opus.**

Along with Frank Miller's *The Dark Knight Returns*, it inspired – for better or worse – an entire genre of determinedly dark and gritty superhero comics but much more importantly, it elevated comics to the kind of critical attention that the medium had rarely, if ever, received. To date, *Watchmen* remains the only graphic novel to win a Hugo Award and was also the only graphic novel to appear on *Time* magazine's 2005 list of the 100 best English-language novels from 1923 to the present day.

However, Moore's relationship with what is arguably his signature work is a decidedly mixed one. Certainly, he's immensely proud of the series and what it achieved, but thanks to standard industry contracts of the time, Moore's royalties were severely limited, which understandably left a profoundly bitter aftertaste. Moore's anger at the situation – disputes over which led to the permanent souring of his relationship with DC – is easy to understand when you consider just how much the publisher has benefited from the immensely successful *Watchmen*. The collected edition is currently on its 19th printing (excluding last year's best-selling hardcover edition) and the book provides DC with a not-inconsiderable degree of critical cachet.

It's been 20 years since *Watchmen* debuted. Looking back, did you anticipate the huge impact it has achieved since?
Yes and no. If you're asking did I anticipate before issue one that the book would have the impact it would, then no. No idea at all. As far as me and Dave Gibbons knew, we were embarking upon something that was perhaps a slightly darker, more ironic take on the superhero, a kind of outgrowth of some of the ideas that I'd already kicked around in *Marvelman*. Instead of *Marvelman* having one single character, we could do like a whole continuity of characters and apply the same kind of realistic sensibilities. But what we expected to get out of it was a slightly darker superhero comic.

When did you realise that you had something special on your hands?
Around about issue three. In fact, I could probably tell you which panel, that while I was writing issue three, I suddenly realised what we could do with *Watchmen* – we had somehow broken through in to a whole new possibility in the language of comics. By issue four, I knew that this was going to turn some heads. By the end of the series, I think at the time I actually said: "It will be a good 15 years before anyone comes up with anything to match this in terms of complexity".

***Watchmen* is also generally credited with taking the comics medium far closer to literary status than had ever been done before. What do you think made *Watchmen* different?**
What made *Watchmen* work was the fact that I was trying to exploit the possibilities of comics as a medium. Comics are not literature and they are not film and they are not gallery art. They are something different. They have their own kind of language. That we could have the details in the back of the panels telling a whole backstory and we could use them to almost kind of program the reader with certain symbols that would evoke a certain set of associations or an emotional effect. We were able to juxtapose what was happening in the pictures and what was happening in the words to startling effect, here or there. Play with the time frame... do all of these things that you can't do in literature and you can't do in films. It was trying to come up with a language that was unique to comics.

Your scripts are incredibly dense with description – is that because you don't want to leave anything to chance, that you want everything to be just the way you perceive it?
Partly it's that. I don't mind if artists deviate or come up with a better idea than what I have put down in my elaborate script notes. All I want to do is give the greatest possible support. There is also an element that, when I first started in comics, it was very much a situation where I didn't know who was going to be drawing the script. It could be a great artist; it could be someone on their first job. So you tend to try to write, if you like, an 'artist-proof' script, where all the information they need is right there – you're not leaving it up to them to think of